On 13 November, Dost Mohammad Khan left Kabul, accompanied by his son Afzal Khan to whom he had written, telling him ‘he had been received with much kindness and respect’ and urging his son to follow his example and surrender. In Jalalabad the two were reunited with the rest of their harem: Dost Mohammad’s nine wives, the twenty-one spouses of his sons, 102 female slaves and another 210 male slaves and attendants, who along with numerous grandchildren and other relations brought the party to a grand total of 381 people in all.[107] As the news of the Amir’s honourable treatment spread, the number increased dramatically and, according to Mirza ‘Ata, by the time the party arrived at Ludhiana, ‘all the family and dependents of the Amir had arrived: 22 of his sons, 13 of his nephews, and another 29 relations as well as 400 male-servants and 300 female-servants, in total 1,115 persons joined the Amir in exile’.[108]

There was great relief in Kabul and Simla when the Barakzais finally reached Ludhiana at the end of December. Sir Willoughby Cotton, who had been given the job of escorting the Amir to his new residence at the end of his stint as British military commander in Afghanistan, even wrote to his successor to say, ‘You will have nothing to do here. All is peace.’[109]

But in reality the insurgency was by no means over. Akbar Khan, Dost Mohammad’s most warlike son, had just managed to escape from Bukhara. He would soon prove a potent new centre of resistance, and far more violent, ruthless and effective than his father had ever been.